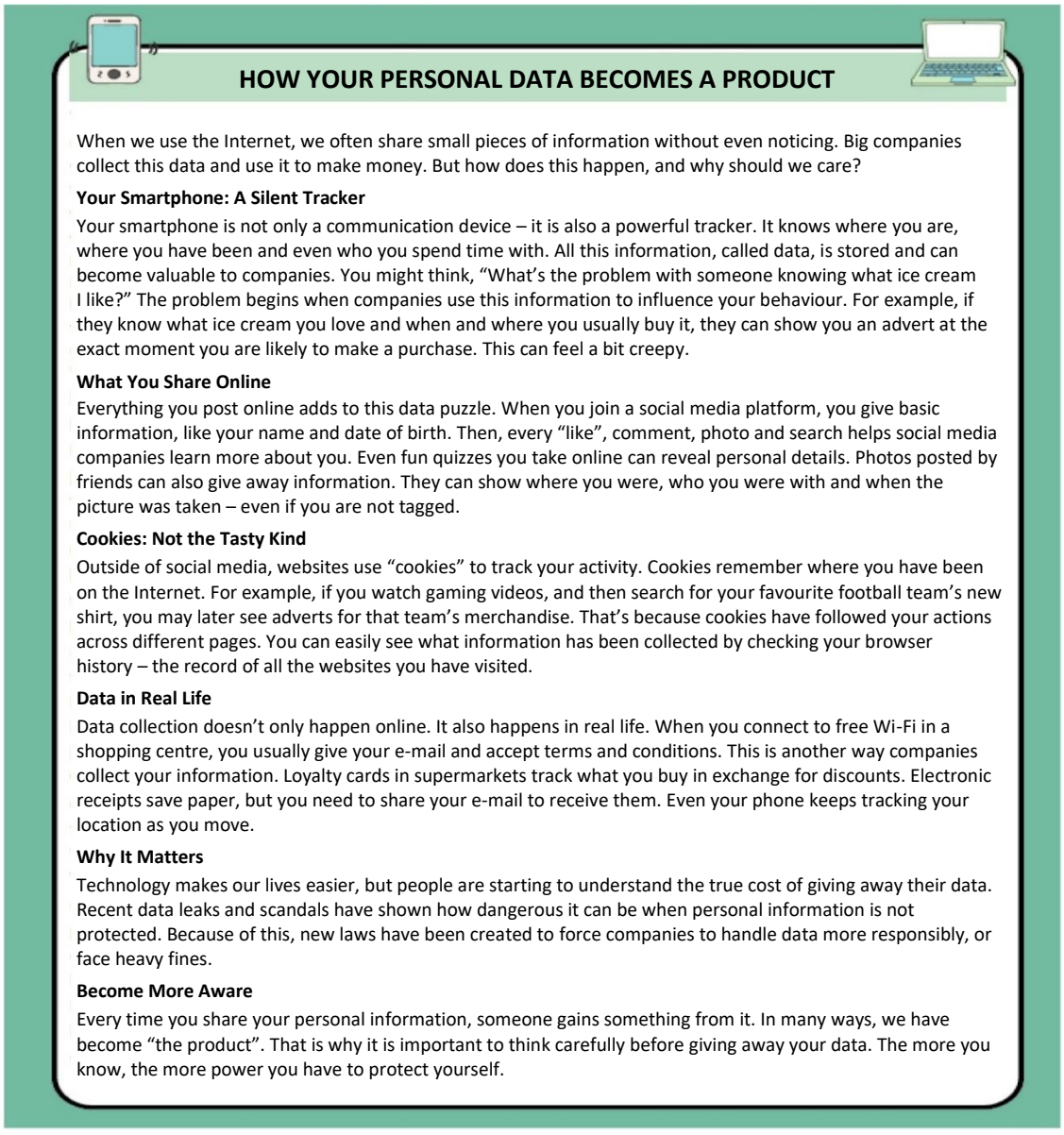
B2 - Written Mediation 4: Task

Personal Data on the Net

Your German friend Klaus has an 11-year-old brother, Ben. You met Ben when you were on a school exchange in Germany. He has been given his first smartphone, and he is excited about sharing photographs on social media. Klaus would like Ben to use his phone sensibly. You read this article in a magazine, and you think some of the ideas would be useful to help him. Write an e-mail to Klaus explaining the most relevant points. (80-100 words)



HOW YOUR PERSONAL DATA BECOMES A PRODUCT

When we use the Internet, we often share small pieces of information without even noticing. Big companies collect this data and use it to make money. But how does this happen, and why should we care?

Your Smartphone: A Silent Tracker

Your smartphone is not only a communication device – it is also a powerful tracker. It knows where you are, where you have been and even who you spend time with. All this information, called data, is stored and can become valuable to companies. You might think, "What's the problem with someone knowing what ice cream I like?" The problem begins when companies use this information to influence your behaviour. For example, if they know what ice cream you love and when and where you usually buy it, they can show you an advert at the exact moment you are likely to make a purchase. This can feel a bit creepy.

What You Share Online

Everything you post online adds to this data puzzle. When you join a social media platform, you give basic information, like your name and date of birth. Then, every "like", comment, photo and search helps social media companies learn more about you. Even fun quizzes you take online can reveal personal details. Photos posted by friends can also give away information. They can show where you were, who you were with and when the picture was taken – even if you are not tagged.

Cookies: Not the Tasty Kind

Outside of social media, websites use "cookies" to track your activity. Cookies remember where you have been on the Internet. For example, if you watch gaming videos, and then search for your favourite football team's new shirt, you may later see adverts for that team's merchandise. That's because cookies have followed your actions across different pages. You can easily see what information has been collected by checking your browser history – the record of all the websites you have visited.

Data in Real Life

Data collection doesn't only happen online. It also happens in real life. When you connect to free Wi-Fi in a shopping centre, you usually give your e-mail and accept terms and conditions. This is another way companies collect your information. Loyalty cards in supermarkets track what you buy in exchange for discounts. Electronic receipts save paper, but you need to share your e-mail to receive them. Even your phone keeps tracking your location as you move.

Why It Matters

Technology makes our lives easier, but people are starting to understand the true cost of giving away their data. Recent data leaks and scandals have shown how dangerous it can be when personal information is not protected. Because of this, new laws have been created to force companies to handle data more responsibly, or face heavy fines.

Become More Aware

Every time you share your personal information, someone gains something from it. In many ways, we have become "the product". That is why it is important to think carefully before giving away your data. The more you know, the more power you have to protect yourself.

In written mediation, you need to interpret the content of the article and be able to explain the information in it in an informal or colloquial way.

Refer to the document you have been asked to read. But do not copy it. Paraphrase the ideas there.

